

ILLUSTRATION BY RAJ VERMA



sector, for in it lies the opportunity for us to accelerate job creation.

I now move to the second part of the prayer—*Sarbat Da Bhalla*. In this phrase, we invoke the Almighty for the well-being and prosperity of not just ourselves and our loved ones, but everyone, in a most inclusive sense. In many ways it is not different from the development framework of *Sabka Saath Sabka Vikas*. It is clear to me that to achieve this Sustainability, Equitability, and Inclusiveness must be the three pillars on which we must both aspire and design our growth aspirations.

Given the precarious state of our environment, I believe that we will simply not be able to support the kind of growth we aspire to, without sustainability being embedded in everything we plan for, going forward. Moreover, focussing on this would not just drive national savings, but could also create humungous opportunities, both for businesses and consumers. Let me illustrate this with a few examples. The nutrient value of our soil is precariously depleted and high fertiliser prices have driven the subsidy bill to over ₹2 lakh crore this year. This is not

just a huge macro burden, but also puts pressure on farmers, water consumption, and the quality of food we consume as a nation. Building a farmer and consumer-led movement to adopt natural farming is a huge opportunity for all. Another example lies in making middle India travel largely by mass transport, using their private vehicles sparingly. While this requires continued investments in our public transport systems and last-mile connectivity, it also adds to savings for the middle and lower income Indians, improves productivity, reduces pollution from transportation and the burden on import of fuels.

Next, we must ensure that the next phase of growth has its dividends spread far more equitably. For all the progress we have to show since independence, the share of the bottom half of our population in our GDP has declined from the mid-teens to around 10 per cent, with most of the gains accruing to the top 10 per cent of us. As we grow, we will need to ensure that growth is not jobless and that wages are fair. In parallel, we will need to ensure that some of the gains are invested in materially improving the ease and quality of living for the ordinary Indian.

Finally, we must aim for our growth to be built on the pillar of inclusiveness. Our biggest challenge here lies in equitably including women in India's growth. Reversing the decline in participation of women in the labour force will unleash huge economic and social dividends.

I have no doubt that with the right steps, the next 25 years could well set India on the path of not just an India@100 that we all dream about, but truly make the 21st century India's century—in the most holistic sense. **BT**

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